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ENGL109H

14 August 2026

Colony life.



An ant, alone, mid-stride, asking "where are we right now?"... It is common for people to feel lost especially outside of their communities.

The slimy sweat of my forehead was breaded by the dust particles flying in a plateau of the valley. If you would have put my huge childish head into a fryer, it wouldn't have looked much different than a nugget. The weather is arid, so perhaps we were all frying, with no regard of what the sun was doing to us, to our sweaty children's faces.

Some days we were aliens, and some other days we were fighting in a war that history hasn't yet written, but that day we were competing for the Golden Boot and I was

goalie: the default position for the slowest kid. The fencepost was two half-sipped bottles of Gatorade.

In third grade, my obsession with superfoods allowed two kids to steal hemp seeds from my backpack and play pretend that I had intoxicated them. Later that day I became the first eight-year-old of my city to have an investigation file for possible possession of marihuana, because the English teacher read the header of the Wikipedia page for hemp seeds and the word cannabis was highlighted in the dark blue that indicates you can click to investigate what the word marihuana means.

It took having my parents bring in a ticket that proved we had bought the food in a legal supermarket in Arizona to make the cops and my teachers leave my personal image alone. It was the first and last school suspension in my entire life.

In return, I made sure that every single question they copied from my exams was wrong by always selecting the wrong answers and deleting them only after they relaxed their sight (a technique I kept using for the rest of my academic life).

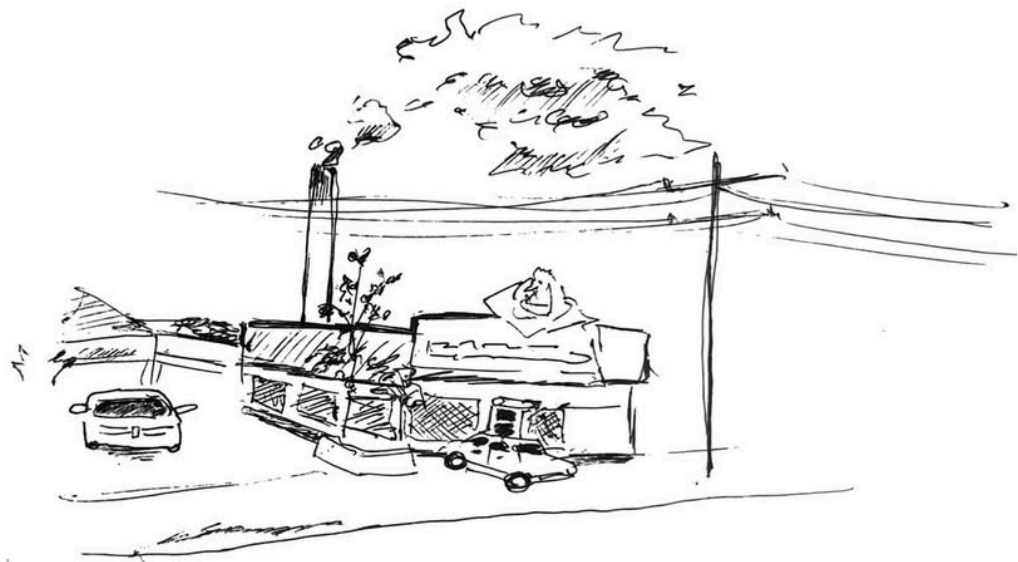
The growing industrialization of Nogales, Sonora, Mexico, drove a bunch of families in the early 1990s to settle, creating the Luis Donaldo Colosio neighborhood, the largest “squatting” in Latin America. There is some unfairness in calling it squatting. When travelers from the east of the thirteen colonies moved their explorations westwards, it was a tale of bravery for which legality had no say. But when it was migration for the sake of farming and selling hard-earned work, the law immediately claims the land poisoned by the presence of brown conquistadores, “ill-mannered people” who in the present, even after

generations of living in the same colonies, aren't semantically worthy of their home in the laws of legislature.

The way I see it, the gold rush for the Nogales citizen was a new country right in their noses, ready for the commercial exchange that comes with a border. Our golden boot wasn't made of gold; it was made of the bronze in the railroads. Perhaps the difference is that we are not a coastal city; as a matter of fact, the top of the hills in Nogales is a little ugly, and when a millionaire proposes moving to Mars and shows pictures of a hill with a numbered name, those pictures are only a little less flattering than the dry seasons of the area. Truly, we all know that our homes are plopped in mismatched architectural styles into a neighborhood with no regard for the (lack of) natural design of the place. The sense of universality is blended in with the sense of individuality to the point that one's home makes a whole. Instead of a suburb, we are a collection of domestic cereal boxes in an ant hill. But there is something much more important than the landscape growing beneath the homes.

On Wednesdays, the grilled chicken from Pollo Feliz is on discount; you can buy one and a half grilled chickens with tortillas and sauce for way cheaper than you would usually acquire food anywhere else. Back in the day, my sister and I dreaded it; we called it poverty food without realizing the weight of our words in the real world. It indeed was; we shared the line of Pollo Feliz with the people from the nearby neighborhood, much less economically lucky than we were at the time (even though, objectively, we've ever only owned the money that puts food on the table). A bunch of kids would run around and hit

their heads against the table, apparently an almost universal experience for the energetic kind of folk, and then you would hear a line of so many young women, maybe mothers, maybe sisters, all scolding the kid for clapping their forehead against the floor tiles on top of the table. Maybe a bit of my aversion towards it came from not wanting to make a line. I didn't want to imagine myself as an ant in a conga line, crashing into all of the other ants that bisected the alignment once they found food.



The Pollo Feliz that my sister and I would go to. You can see the smoke coming out of it from afar.

Despite the commentary in this essay, the food is actually amazing and an honest source of protein.

I've gained 20 pounds in a bulking season from eating here when I go back home.

I've been away from the city for a few years, maybe as a punishment of my younger classism, I can sit in silence in my bed sometimes and the hissing of the chicken's breast

being squished against the coal-stained grill will run towards me, followed by the smell of corn tortillas. I miss the line of the Pollo Feliz, the parking lot accidents at the entrance. None of us knew each other; we were rough to each other and expected larger things, maybe that's why we hated our own poverty; that's why barely anyone gave credit to the chicken we were eating for barely any money (if it weren't for ironic comments about enjoying it). But we as a society of strangers held each other in the critical eyes we did because we cared for each other; yes, jealousy existed, but we were holding our people to the same standards as ourselves. The symbolism of the chicken was not dreading an actually protein-complete food; it was looking at each other in the eyes and asking why any of us would need to be here if we were all the same beneath the Pollo Feliz ceiling. The common pattern is that there is an immanent veil on all of us in the shape of a Pollo Feliz Ceiling, under the Mexican sun, a veil shooting out the smoke that reeks of poblano and the carcass of a headless hen. And I miss that warmth, the one that lacks when I read a Bukowski poem.

the flesh covers the bone

and they put a mind

in there and

sometimes a soul,

and the women break

vases against the walls

and the men drink too

much

and nobody finds the

one

but they keep

looking

crawling in and out

of beds.

flesh covers

the bone and the

flesh searches

for more than

flesh.

there's no chance

at all:

we are all trapped

by a singular

fate.

nobody ever finds

the one.

the city dumps fill

the junkyards fill

the madhouses fill

the hospitals fill

the graveyards fill

nothing else

fills.

(from Love Is A Dog From Hell)

But is there actually nothing else?

Canela was named by my cousin and I, inspired by the name “Isabelle”, a small yellow dog from Animal Crossing, named exactly the same in the Spanish version of the videogames. Canela is far from being a small dog; she is daughter to a German Shepherd with pedigree and a stray that sort of resembles a UFC fighter at times (would you believe that strays fill the city 10:1?), she can chase a car well at a 30-mph speed limit, and her favorite pastime is following the bunnies who mate under metal scraps in the rugged plot of land that my aunt owns. I’ve had to chase her away from neighboring schools plenty of times because the dog (far from any stupidity) knows that it will be rewarded with lunch leftovers if it can squeeze through the middle school’s fence.

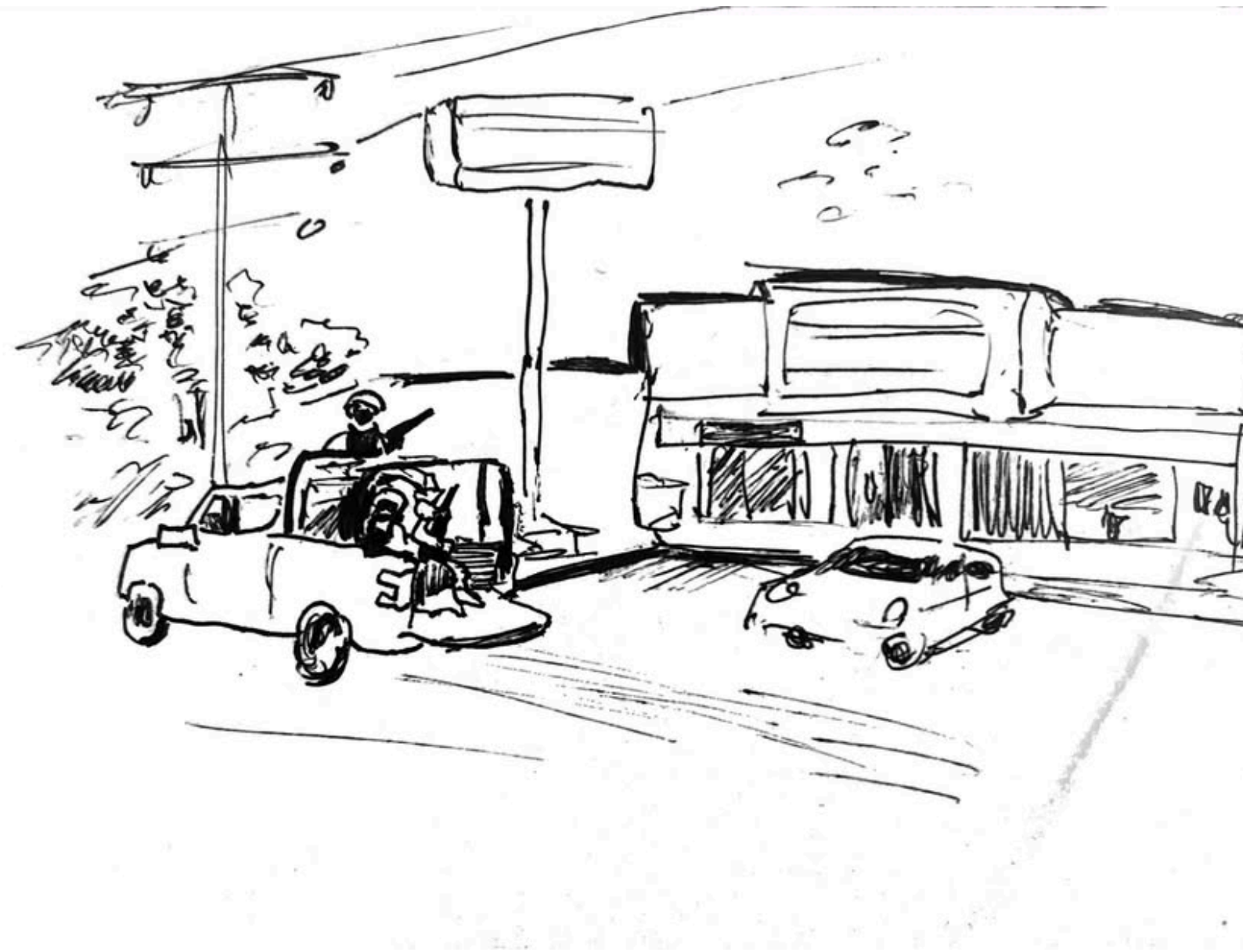
I wasn’t there to chase Canela down that day; I believe I may have been further away from home, likely somewhere in Phoenix at the time. A girl was stabbed twice in the girls’ restroom of that same school, once in her right armpit, and once in her upper back, the cuts approximately 2x2cm each, by her classmate at the time.

It is difficult to point fingers and degenerate the problem in pieces like clockwork, like mathematical variables that will show the common interactions between each mechanical piece of the puzzle of what caused this. There are policemen to handle that, but they were probably riding around an Oxxo looking for snacks. The story, however, strips

away that both of these girls may have grown up in a similar situation, eating the same chicken on Wednesdays, their case becomes a number in many more and suddenly the subtle interactions between the people who live there become a stereotype. The school is now considered a criminal nest, when in reality it's the only education some may receive for free and close to home.

Nothing was said to outsiders about the conditions or grounds for such a problem to occur. I have a guess I can't prove: that kid infighting, like a civil war, has something to do with how close the other person's face is to a mirror. But I don't actually know. What I know is the confirmation of that closed loop has the smoke blowing out the chimney, and ashes of coal over our skins.

There is a closed loop of events becoming a number.



A police truck outside of an Oxxo: they characteristically drive around with their men on the back of their trucks, guns out. It is rare that they use them at all.

When the teacher claimed I was selling marihuana, I remember still wanting to play with those kids; I grew with them even if I didn't want to accept it at the time. The wars that we played were our real wars, our strategical (albeit primal) wins and losses within each other's own headspace, the country that our family had raised within our brains. We would lie to each other, but we never hated each other; as a matter of fact, we still remember each other's birthdays.

Sometimes, we do not get the full story of a person's humanity, their fight for survival. We do not tell apart the circumstances that kids have to go through in the environments they live in; we are consumers of a headline, and we rely heavily on the investigatory work of someone whose intent we are unable to qualify away from the formalisms, even away from the circumstances of the people they report about. We are the positive reinforcement to telling everybody that the kids in the poor areas of our city are indeed about to grow up to be criminals, in the case of northern Mexico, narcos. A few streets away from the same school where Canela goes to get fed extra, a flower stand stays up till 3:00 AM; no bouquet has ever been moved, and the corner is not naturally a dating spot, if anything, it is an ugly place. This spot is being attended by a kid who barely looks



A drawing of a kid standing under a public lamp, with a flower bouquet stand to his left.

The place where he is located doesn't match any place where couples go for dates,

and the spot is hidden away enough for the clientele to be low all week.

The stand is close enough to the school where the stabbing occurred.

I wondered if the kid wanted to take a break from work.

The unanimous decision of pretending to be anything else but ourselves in the playgrounds possibly came from this misrepresentation of the population, the estrangement that kids had with the circumstances they had lived in. And perhaps this is the reason why I tell the stories in this order, where the cops were looking at a kid who possessed marihuana, we all were looking at the novelty of mysterious seeds I had put in a Ziploc bag, and a childish joke that turned out too far; the story only took looking at a damned grocery

receipt in the back of my mother's purse (waiting to be used in returning something in case it didn't work for us, since we needed every cent); where the rest of the world looks at aliens, my people were just looking for better chances; Nogales still receives immigrants, and our churches and organizations still approach them with open arms; we are a stopping point, a plate of grilled chicken and salsa in our fellows' way to the land of milk and honey; where I was looking at the poverty of my people, feeling a dense sense of shame from eating the food that the "prole" class (a despective term used in Mexico for the proletariat) was getting with me; I was forgetting the smells and flavors that filled my home when money was barely available to survive; I forgot to tell the story in between the lines, the small amount of details that turns a bad person and a possible criminal into a justified character with a bad methodology; when Canela would escape her home to look for food, she was not looking at the potential of kids to be machines of violence; she was looking at a community blind to her status as a stray and her dirty look (acquired from playing with construction crews in the area); when the people of my city drive by that flower stand, they are smart enough to immediately tell that drugs are being sold, but they don't see the kid who has been inducted into a lifestyle that can cost his last breath.

Nonetheless, so be it, in my personal opinion, an ant pile in a blur of a martian community, people need not untangle the conspiracy and the hard-cast truths from one another, we need not differentiate our love from our hate. Not because they are unequal but because the energy could be put into looking at one another with the love we deserve next time we are waiting on a line. It is the fact that we have grown one another in a circumstance so similar, under the growling smoke of the "maquiladora," and sharing the

same few restaurants, that makes our broader community a home. While this is universal, I'll never deny that it is in Nogales where we can all communally agree to go to the same bar on a payday. Yes, we are a colony, but isn't that how ants survive in the first place?